Lesson 16

Judgmental

"Do not judge, and you will not be judged."
(Luke 6:37)

"Rebuke a discerning man, and he
will gain knowledge."
(Proverbs 19:25)

Judgmental: inclined to pass judgment or condemn
Rebuke: to convey one's disapproval of; reprove

Christians must exercise great care and discernment when judging the actions of other human beings. We must be especially careful not to condemn others or be hypocritical. We must keep in mind that we ourselves are not perfect, and have our own sin with which to contend. However, this does not mean that Christians should avoid judging the actions of others altogether. It is our Christian obligation to rebuke others who are caught in sin so that they may repent and restore their relationship with God.

Synopsis

Jesus preached that human beings should exercise caution and restraint when judging others.[1,2] He emphasized that we should not judge (that is, condemn) others when we ourselves are engag-

Do not judge, and you will not be judged. Do not condemn, and you will not be condemned.
(Luke 6:37)[1]

Do not judge, or you too will be judged. For in the same way you judge others, you will be judged, and with the measure you use, it will be measured to you.
(Matthew 7:1-2)[2]

ing in the same or even "greater" sins.[3] Such actions would be hypocritical.[4]

Similar cautions about judging others are given elsewhere in the Bible. For example, if we pass judgment on others when we ourselves are engaging in the same sin, we bring condemnation upon ourselves,[5] and we will not escape God's judgment.[6]

God is the only true judge of mankind.[7,8] On the final day of judgment, it is God to whom we will have to give an account of our

Why do you look at the speck of sawdust in your brother's eye and pay no attention to the plank in you own eye? How can you say to your brother, "Let me take the speck out of your eye," when all the time there is a plank in your own eye?
(Matthew 7:3-4)[3]

You hypocrite, first take the plank out of your own eye, and then you will see clearly to remove the speck from your brother's eye.
(Matthew 7:5)[4]

You, therefore, have no excuse, you who pass judgment on someone else, for at whatever point you judge the other, you are condemning yourself, because you who pass judgment do the same things.
(Romans 2:1)[5]

So when you, a mere man, pass judgment on them and yet do the same things, do you think you will escape God's judgment?
(Romans 2:3)[6]

There is only one Lawgiver and Judge, the one who is able to save and destroy.
(James 4:12)[7]

It is the Lord who judges me. Therefore, judge nothing before the appointed time; wait till the Lord comes.
(1 Corinthians 4:4-5)[8]

lives—not man.[9] We should seek to be ready for the day of God's judgment. For Christians, this will be a day when we are judged in terms of the rewards we will receive in heaven.[10,11]

God's Guidance

Despite biblical warnings against judging others—especially hypocritical judgment—it is clear from the scriptures that we should rebuke our fellow Christians when they are caught in sin and are breaking God's moral laws.[12] Such rebuke is important to help restore the person to righteousness, and is a way of showing love for the sinner.[13] In the end, rebuking a sinner from the error of his ways can save his life.[14]

The Bible does not contain any standard "formula" for rebuking others. In some instances the scriptures recommend that rebuke

So then, each of us will give an account of himself to God.
Therefore let us stop passing judgment on one another.
(Romans 14:12-13)[9]

Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those
who are in Christ Jesus.
(Romans 8:1)[10]

Behold I am coming soon! My reward is with me,
and I will give to everyone according to what he has done.
(Revelation 22:12)[11]

So watch yourselves. "If your brother sins, rebuke him,
and if he repents, forgive him.
(Luke 17:3)[12]

Those whom I love I rebuke and discipline.
So be earnest, and repent.
(Revelation 3:19)[13]

My brothers, if one of you should wander from the truth
and someone should bring him back, remember this:
Whoever turns a sinner from the error of his way will
save him from death and cover over
a multitude of sins.
(James 5:19-20)[14]

should be frank,[15] but gentle.[16] Elsewhere, it recommends that rebuke should be public, so that it serves as a warning to others.[17] Finally, the Bible recommends that when we rebuke someone, we use great patience and care.[18]

Perhaps the most effective way of rebuking another person is to simply "speak the truth in love."[19] Humbly point the sinner to God's commandments and the truth as contained in the holy scriptures; the Word of God was designed for such purposes.[20]

In the final analysis, rebuke is not something to be avoided, but embraced. If a fellow Christian rebukes you, consider yourself fortunate.[21] You would be wise to listen to rebuke and learn as you

Rebuke your neighbor frankly
so you will not share in his guilt.
(Leviticus 19:17)[15]

Brothers, if someone is caught in a sin,
you who are spiritual should restore him gently.
But watch yourself, or you also may be tempted.
(Galatians 6:1)[16]

Those who sin are to be rebuked publicly,
so that the others may take warning.
(1 Timothy 5:20)[17]

Preach the Word; be prepared in season and out of season;
correct, rebuke and encourage—with great patience
and careful instruction.
(2 Timothy 4:2)[18]

Instead, speaking the truth in love, we will in all things
grow up into him who is the Head, that is, Christ.
(Ephesians 4:15)[19]

All Scripture is God-breathed and is useful for teaching,
rebuking, correcting and training in righteousness.
(2 Timothy 3:16)[20]

Like an earring of gold or an ornament of fine gold
is a wise man's rebuke to a listening ear.
(Proverbs 25:12)[21]

can from it.[22-24] After all, your response to rebuke may have consequences for eternity.[14]

He who listens to a life-giving rebuke
will be at home among the wise.
(Proverbs 15:31)[22]

Rebuke a discerning man,
and he will gain knowledge.
(Proverbs 19:25)[23]

Whoever gives heed to instruction prospers,
and blessed is he who trusts in the LORD.
(Proverbs 16:20)[24]